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## Colophon

Based on the novel *The Little Fuzzy* by H. Beam Piper.  
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## A Little Fuzzy Reframed

HEART/MIND



Based on *The Little Fuzzy* by H. Beam  
Piper, reimagined by Janet Burks

HEART/MIND



# Chapter 1

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A Little Fuzzy Reframed

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Tuesday dawned hot and windless, the scarlet sun climbing into a hard, breezy sky. I had been awake for hours, moving among the neatly arranged supplies of my camp, checking instruments and reviewing contingencies. The Fuzzies fitted in the distance, clever but irrelevant distractions. Sapience in a small, defenseless species could undo everything the Company had painstakingly built, and I intended to prevent that at all costs.

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After breakfast with Malin, I walked the perimeter of the camp, my boots crunching on dry soil. "We must be precise," I said, voice low but firm. "Don't misinterpret ge-

dunk, one looking observes, and someone might declare their sapient. *Entire chapters, entire classes—gone.*"

Malin lowered, notebook open. "But... they do show intelligence. Their behavior—"

"Learned behavior, Malin," I interrupted, letting a faint smile touch my lips, my hand not harsh. *Reflection, intellect, curiosity—they're clever, yet. Remarkably adaptable. But awareness is not reason. Curiosity is not morality. Observe, record, don't romanticize. That is what separates sense from sentiment.*

Ruth Othman and Gard van Riebeck approached, crossing the dusty stretch of ground. I straightened, greeting them with calm warmth.

"Good morning, Dr. Kellogg," Ruth said, smiling. "It's not, is it?"

"Morning, Ruth," I replied smoothly. "Yes, but manageable. You'll see the Fuzzies soon enough—but remember, observe, don't interpret."

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Gerd raised an eyebrow, arms crossed. “*Not* arguing they aren’t sapient? *Little Fuzzy*—faced with danger—chooses to think rather than flee. *Isn’t* that... remarkable?”

I inclined my head slightly, keeping my voice steady and persuasive. “Remarkable, yes, but cleverness in the face of risk is learned adaptation, not abstract thought. They learn, they adapt—but they do not reason beyond the immediate. Our test is to ensure observations remain objective. Let impression override fact, and the consequences would be catastrophic.”

Ruth’s gaze flicked to Malin, troubled. “Dr. Malin has found nothing to indicate true sapience, correct?”

“Exactly,” I said firmly, but with calm assurance. “We must ensure it stays that way. Observation only. Reenactment or anthropomorphizing—even unintentionally— risks disaster. The Company, the colony, the fragile order of Zarahke—*all* depend on clear, rational thought.”

Ruth smiled, considering, and Gerd nodded slowly. After a moment, Ruth glanced toward Jack’s camp. “Well, we should check in with the others. *Little Fuzzy* and the rest won’t wait for us.”

“Of course,” I said, inclining my head. “Malin, Juan—you’ll accompany them? Make sure observation remains precise.”

Malin and Juan nodded, gathering their equipment. “We’ll pick them up from Jack’s camp and ensure nothing is misinterpreted,” Malin said.

As Ruth and Gerd crossed toward Jack’s camp, I returned to pacing with Malin. The sun climbed higher, heedless, across the run, the Fuzzies played, and Jack’s group moved about, tirelessly unaware. I allowed my eyes to soften slightly, just enough to hint at warmth. Closer, adaptable, amusing—but sapient? Not yet. And that was precisely how I intended to keep it.

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stack stones in a small, solemn pile. I couldn’t look. I couldn’t look away.

Lurt removed his beret, bowed his head, and when he replaced it, he drew his pistol. His wife, when he spoke, was almost gentle. “I am now going to arrest Leonard Kellogg for the murder of a sapient being.”

My mind went blank. He couldn’t do this. He couldn’t. I was the one defending order, the one who understood the framework—the definitions that made civilization possible. Sapience wasn’t a matter of emotion. It was measurable. Quantifiable. Real.

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They couldn’t simply decide these creatures were people because they felt like people. That wasn’t science. That was chaos.

And yet, as Lurt stepped closer, something within me trembled—a headline crack in my certainty. Because the sound the Fuzzies made wasn’t chaos. It was grief—unmistakable, ungarded, true.

For one breath, I felt something twist inside me—small, fragile, terrified. The terrible thought that I might have been wrong.

Then I pushed it down. I had to.

No—the world had gone mad. That was all. And I was the last sane man left in it.

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mal complaint. Jack Hadleeve attacked me, struck me repeatedly, and in the process killed Kurt Bach. I am here in the line of duty, asking that the law be enforced."

Lurt listened, expression unchangeable, arms folded. When I finished, he nodded once, measured, almost slow enough to be deliberate. "Dr. Kallag," he said. "I understand your complaint. You've made it. But it looks like self-defense. That is the determination we have to follow. According to procedure, halfway we'll be placed under arrest, unless further evidence contradicts it."

I pressed the tissue harder to my face and nodded, trying to contain the relief that the law—procedure it-self—still functioned in the chaos. "Thank you, Lieutenant," I said. My voice was quieter now, controlled, almost calm.

He gave no reply beyond a brief, curt nod. Lurt began to walk back toward the constabulary car, leaving me to gather myself, to regain some composure. I started moving toward Marlin, each step deliberate, forcing my muscles to obey. My thoughts raced, parsing the events I had just recounted, reconstructing every motion, every decision, in case I had to repeat it again. Then I heard it.

"Wow, George," Holloway said, his tone calm, almost theatrical, slicing through the uneasy quiet. "I know how much composure and accusation against Leonard Kallag, charging him with the unlawful and unjustified killing of a sapient being—to wit, Goldilocks."

For a second, I couldn't process the words. A sapient being. Then they struck, and the world seemed to tilt. I tried to speak, to protest, but no sound came.

Lurt's gaze shifted to the Fuzzies. They were lifting her now, carrying the little body with a care that felt disturbingly human. The smallest one—Cinderella—held what looked like a tiny weapon, walking behind the others like a guard of honor. The rest began to

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"Observation first, Maclin," I said quietly, letting my voice carry a calm authority. "Working else. Let sentiment or speculation creep in, and we lose everything."

Maclin nodded, jotting notes, and I allowed myself a brief smile.

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## Chapter 2

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### A Little Fuzzy Reframed

Lunt was talking again—about verification, statements, self-defense—but I barely heard him. Everything was slipping out of my control, the narrative twisting itself around me. Holloway, the aggressor, had become the hero, Berch, who had tried to help, was now the victim. And I—I, who had acted out of duty—was being recast as the villain.

Rainford's voice cut through the chaos of my thoughts.

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*"Just what did happen, Jack? And whose side is he on?"*

He was pointing—at me. Or rather, at van Riebeck, who stood between me and Mallin like a warden, his thumbs hooked casually in his pistol belt. The gesture was almost lazy, but there was nothing casual about the look in his eyes.

It struck me, then, how absurd it all was—how quickly I had become the one needing to be guarded. Only an hour ago, these same men had deferred to my authority, nodded at my conclusions, treated my words as the Company's own. Now van Riebeck stood watch as though I were some dangerous animal who might bolt or bite.

I could feel the weight of it pressing down—the shift in power, the quiet judgment hanging in the air. Every man here had already chosen a side, though some would admit it aloud.

I wanted to speak, to remind them who I was, what I had stood for—the work, the evidence, the discipline that had held this world together. But the words wouldn't come. All I could do was sit there, watching. Holloway and Rainford confer like men discussing the weather, while van Riebeck's hand lingered near his weapon, just in case reason itself decided to turn violent.

When the second car arrived, I straightened, trying to steady my voice despite the pounding in my skull and the blood that ran unchecked from my nose. "Captain!" I said, "I want to make a for-

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Goodbacks—the little Fuzzy lying still in the dust—was a tragedy. I didn't deny that. But tragedies were part of discovery; they always had been. It was my duty to prevent sentiment from undoing the Company's work. Someone had to hold the line between science and hysteria.

Yet their eyes were on me—wide, accusing—as though I had done something heinous.

Malin had opened the first-aid kit by now. Gerd, seeing the constabulary had tossed his pistol. I tried to find someone, anyone, who still believed in reason. "There's the murderer!" I said, pointing at Holloway.

"You have him re-handled. Why don't you arrest him?"

No one moved. Lant turned away, speaking to Holloway in a low voice. The others—Malin, Ortheris, van Riebeeck—drifted like mourners at a wake. And the fuzzies... They gathered around the little body, leaning softly, a thin, aching sound that pierced the air. It graded against every instinct I had to dismiss it.

They couldn't grieve, I told myself. They couldn't understand what grief was. They were animals—that was the conclusion, the verified result, the Company's position.

But the way they moved—the way they lifted her with such care—unsettled me in a way I couldn't name. I forced the thought away before it could take shape.

Ruth Ortheris was crouched among them, stroking one gently. Her eyes shone with tears. The sight was almost unbearable—a scientist, surrendering objectivity for emotion. We weren't supposed to feel this way. You couldn't empathize a species into sapience. You couldn't turn pity into proof. I told myself that again and again, but the words felt hollow.

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I arrived at Jack Holloway's camp just after dawn. Gerd van Riebeeck was already pacing beside the living hut, restless as ever, while the fuzzies darted through the dust, playing some incomprehensible little game.

"Morning, Doctor," Gerd said, shading his eyes from the rising sun.

"Morning, Gerd," I replied. "Ready to move?"

He nodded, and I helped him into the jeep. The robots locked up the faint dust of the clearing as we lifted off, returning to my own camp. The familiar sight of the living hut and neatly arranged supplies brought a measure of calm. Here, at least, order reigned. The instruments were in their places, the tape tidy, and the routines precise. It was a small sanctuary against the unpredictability of the world.

We disembarked and entered the hut. Gerd looked about him with faint curiosity, glancing at the charts and instruments.

Once settled, we prepared for the day's exploration. Maps were consulted, equipment checked. Malin and Juan will join us later at the stream, but for now it was only Gerd and me, heading upriver to examine a section of Cold Creek I had long suspected would yield interesting traces of Fuzzy activity.

The air grew cooler as we ascended the creek, scented faintly of wet rock and mineral. The land slipped past, bare hills interrupted by thorn forest, and I felt the familiar satisfaction of moving with purpose. Gerd, ever impatient, walked alongside, scanning every footprint and broken twig.

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We found the traces first: a scattering of ash, small prints, bones gnawed clean and stacked together. Then, in a patch of fallen timber, we saw it: a mound of stones. Noat, did benats.

Geed stopped, crouched, stared. "A grave," he breathed.

I came beside him, feeling my arms. "Or refuse. They dig for all manner of things—roots, food storage, hiding waste from predators. Do not leap to conclusions."

But he was already clearing the stones away, his large hands surprisingly gentle. Beneath, the grass-wrapped form appeared—a small, bearded body of a Fuzzy. Even then, I forced myself to see only what was necessary: pattern, habit, adaptation. Grief was irrelevant; instinct could mimic it perfectly.

"There," I said quietly. "Now you see why we must be careful. Evidence must be curated, not speculated upon. The Company's future—and, indeed, ours—rests on what we prove, not what we wish to believe."

Geed, of course, ignored me. He photographed, gestured, mumbled about morality, refusal, grief. His words tumbled, unchecked, and I recognized the danger of sentiment creeping into observation.

"Geed," I said, more sharply. "Stop. There is nothing further to be gained here. We will return to camp and report it responsibly." I called Malin on the communicator and instructed him to meet us at camp immediately.

Malin was pale when we returned. Ruth Griffiths and young Juan joined us a few minutes later, their faces tense. I recounted what we had found—carefully, factually. Malin swallowed hard at the mention of the cairn.

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The world had gone mad. It was the only explanation that fit—the only one I could bear to accept.

The taste of blood lingered in my mouth, thick and metallic, sliding from my nose to the back of my throat. My face throbbled as if it had doubled in size; my eyes watered uncontrollably. The tissue in my hand was soaked, but I pressed it tighter anyway. The pain barely registered. What cut deepest wasn't the blow—it was the humiliation. And now they were all staring at me as if I were the madman.

"What's happened, Jack? Why didn't you wait till we got here?" Lust said sharply.

"This maniac assaulted me and murdered that man over there!" I shouted, because someone had to speak sense into the chaos. But even as the words left my mouth, I heard the storm in them—too sharp, too desperate. It didn't sound like authority. It sounded like a man losing control.

Lieutenant Lust's eyes fixed on me, cool and steady, the eyes of a man who had already made his judgment.

"Is your name Jack too?" he asked flatly.

"My name's Leonard Kellogg, and I'm a chief of division with the Company—"

"Then keep quiet till I ask you something."

Keep quiet. The words landed like another blow. But I bit down my anger. I couldn't afford to appear emotional now—not when the truth was already slipping through other people's hands. I told myself that if I just remained calm, rational, professional, everything would make sense again. It had to.

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## Chapter 4

HEART/MIND

### A Little Fuzzy Reframed

"We cannot punish that," he whispered. "Not without verification. It could destroy the charter before we can even prove the cause."

Geed barked a laugh. "You mean it will destroy your bonuses."

I regarded him mildly. "Emotionalism helps no one. A scientist must learn that compromise without discipline is chaos. The Federation would not thank us for declaring a native race sapient on flimsy evidence. Nor would the Company."

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He cursed me in Sheetan, threw his cigarette to the ground, and stormed out of the hut, slamming the door behind him. Silence reigned for a few moments, broken only by the faint hum of the generator and the soft chittering of Fuzzies near the edge of camp. I poured a little water into a tin cup, drank, and set it down carefully.

"Observation first," I reminded Malik. "Nothing else. Reason must govern us, not sympathy. If we begin awarding humanity to every pair of bright eyes, we will drown in our own benevolence."

Malik nodded tacitly. Ruth looked troubled.

A while passed in quiet. Then the communicator crackled to life. Jack's voice came first, urgent.

"I want to talk to Kellogg."

"Doctor Kellogg is very busy at present," Birch replied evenly.

"We're going to be a damned sight busier. This is moving day. The whole gang of you have to eighteen hundred to get off my grant."

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I stepped forward and, with a firm motion, placed a hand on Borch's shoulder and moved him aside. Borch hesitated for a heartbeat, then fell back, muttering, "What's this nonsense?" I demanded angrily "You can't order us out like this. Why, you gave us permission—"

"Permission conceded. I've called Mike Hekken in Red Hill. He's sending his scores back for the stuff he brought here. Laurence Luft will have a couple of droppers here, too. I'll expect you to have your personal things aboard your airboat when they arrive."

"Jack—please, you must understand," I said steadily, "this is a mis-understanding. Our work here is proceeding exactly as permitted. No rules have—"

The screen went black before I could finish. Jack's voice vanished.

I slammed my hand lightly on the table. Mallin flinched.

"This isn't fair," he said quietly. "We've done a follow protocol, record what we saw ... and now we're being thrown out like criminals."

I took a deep breath, forcing my temper down to a controlled simmer. "Fair?" I said, voice cold. "Fairness has nothing to do with it. Mallin. Discipline, procedure, proof—these are what matter. And when people ignore them, chaos follows."

I moved to the communicator. "I will call the constabulary," I said firmly. "If the Company refuses to recognize the facts, we will have the law verify our right to return here. We will not be driven off by tantrums and misrepresentations."

Mallin looked uneasy but nodded. "Do you think it will help?"

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I pressed the tissue harder to my nose, feeling the throbb of blood mingling with adrenaline. The constabulary would arrive soon: verification would be sought, facts would be weighed against perception. And yet, in the middle of it all, I was painfully aware that fear had governed my actions, that instinct had overridden judgment, and that the fragile order of the camp had been shattered in a heartbeat.

"That's what this was, more or less," Jack said. "You have a movie camera in your jeep? Well, get some shots of Bosch, and some of Goldflock. Then stand by, and if the Fuzzies start doing anything different, get it all. I don't think you'll be disappointed."

Rainford looked puzzled, glancing between the little body, Bosch, and me, before slowly hobbling his pistol. He returned to his jeep and came back with a camera, moving with deliberate calm that only heightened my awareness of the chaos around us.

Malik immediately began hissing, voice sharp, that as a licensed M.D. he had a right to treat my injuries. I felt the sting of the tissue against my nose, the throbb of blood, the dizziness—but I let him work. Gerd van Riebeck followed him toward the living hut, automatic pressed into the small of Malik's back, eyes scanning, ever cautious.

Then I heard the unmistakable grinding of a constabulary car beside Rainford's airjeep.

George Lunt jumped out, flaps of his holster snapping open, while Ahmed Khadra spoke rapidly into the radio. My mind raced. The law was here. The truth would finally be scrutinized.

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"I must," I said. "We cannot allow disorder to dictate truth. Let them try to dispute the evidence. The constabulary will see it for what it is—our observations, recorded properly, handled respectfully. *That* will stand."

Tomorrow there would be inquiries, investigations, perhaps accusations. But tonight, I had done my duty. Observation first. Containment second. Settlement nowhere.

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# Chapter 3

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"Yes, I saw it." Ruth said softly, eyes wet. "I saw you kick her and jump on her. All she wanted was to show you her new piglet."

I swallowed hard, furious at the misunderstanding yet painfully aware of the consequences of the scene. Around us, the other Fuzzies had tried to lift Goldlocks, realizing she could not rise, and now circled around her in a small, lumbering circle. Their soft, mournful sounds pressed against my mind, a stark reminder of the fine line between perception and intent.

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"Well, when the constabulary get here, you keep quiet," Mallin instructed. "Let me do the talking."

Geed's voice cut in, sardonic. "Understanding witnesses, Mallin? Don't you know everybody'll have to testify at the constabulary post under verification? And you're drawing pay for being a psychologist, are?"

I glanced up. Several of the Fuzzies had lifted their heads, ears twitching, glances fixed toward the southwestern horizon. The sound of approaching vehicles was faint but unmistakable. "Here come the cops, now," Jack muttered under his breath.

Then Ben Ransford's jeep came into view, circling the Kellogg camp with a rebreathе carcass lashed along one side. It idled down swiftly, landing with a controlled thud, and Ransford jumped out, pistol drawn, scanning the scene with the precision of someone accustomed to sudden violence.

"What happened, Jack?" he called, eyes moving from Goldlocks to me, to Beeth, and to the pistol lying discarded beside him. "I get it. Last time anybody pulled a gun on you, they called it suicide."

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"You killed her!" he accused Jack, voice raw. Then he covered himself, "Murderer!" And before anyone could stop him, he started to run toward the living hut.

Gen van Riebeeck fired a warning shot into the ground, halting Jain in his tracks. "You'll stop the next one, Jain," he commanded. "Go help Dr. Aelongo; he got himself hurt."

Malin's voice rose over the murmurs and cries. "Call the constabulary! Ruth, you go; they won't shoot at you."

"Don't bother," Jack said quickly. "I called them. Remember?"

Jinnee produced a wad of tissue and pressed it to my nose, trying to control the bleeding while I read my words, attempting to explain, to justify my actions.

"The little beast attacked me," I said, my words clipped, urgent. "It cut me with that spear it was carrying."

Ruth's voice broke as she knelt beside the little body.

"She came up to her and pulled at his trouser leg, the way they all do when they want to attract your attention," she said. "She wanted her to look at her new piglet." Her voice trembled. "Way he kicked her, and then stomped her to death."

"Wait, keep your mouth shut!" Malin barked. "The thing attacked Lohand, it might have given her a serious wound."

"It did!" I said, pressing the seed of tissue against my nose with one hand, while lifting my trouser leg with the other to show the scratch on my shin. "You saw it yourself."

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# 13

## A Little Fuzzy Reformed

I had barely finished the call to the constabulary when the camp erupted into activity. Boxes and personal effects were gathered, contrabandivity officers hummed, and the meticulous routine of packing began. Karl Berch emerged from the hut, balancing a litter piled with luggage, Jinnee walking alongside to steady the load. Each hip to the arbut was repeated, the rhythmic prose, almost hypnotic.

Malin and I remained at the edge of the awning, exchanging terse words. His frustration was clear, though mine burned hotter, tempered only by the necessity of control.

"You can't let them treat this as trivial," I said quietly, my jaw tight.

"They've worried about paperwork. Lohand, not the truth," Malin replied.

"Then we'll let the constabulary verify it. They'll see what is, and they'll see what is not. No one here will dictate procedure by whom."

Ruth Orthers appeared, briefcase in hand, and sat on the edge of a table beneath the awning, eyes flicking to the Fuzzies at the perimeter.

I had just finished coordinating the last of the arbut loads when a sudden movement caught my eye. Goldlocks was heading straight for the camp, her little silver bell flashing in the sunlight. She moved with unusual speed, almost eagerly, and a prickle of unease ran down my spine.

Before I could think to stop her, she lunged, snaring at my trouser leg the way Fuzzies often did when trying to get attention. But in that instant, instinct overrode my reason. Her motion,

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the jingle of the bell, the sudden shriek she let out—an attack. My heart thumped, my senses sharpened, but with alarm.

"Don't! Forward, stop that!" Ruth's voice screamed from behind, but it barely registered over the ringing in my ears.

Reflex took command. I stepped back, then forward, foot rising in a desperate effort to push her away. The world narrowed to motion and noise, to the tiny body before me and the sharpness of heat. Blood appeared on her face—or perhaps from my own scratch. I could not tell—and my white shoes were splattered in the chaos of the instant.

I acted without thought. Each stamp, each push, was automatic, a response to an attack. I told myself she had lunged, that she had drawn a weapon, that my reactions were nothing more than self-defense against the unpredictable, the unknown.

And yet, even in the middle of it, the cold realization pricked at the back of my mind: she was small. She was fragile. But fear had blinded me.

In a moment, Jack was next to me, I felt a sudden, sharp impact on my face and staggered backward, disoriented. Pain flared through my skull as my hands rose instinctively, trying to protect myself, yet it was all wrong—I was struck so suddenly, so violently. A strangled noise escaped me, half sound, half protest, as if I were trying to speak: Now, please don't misunderstand me...

The next moment, my shirt was caught in a firm grip, and another blow landed squarely against my face. Again. And again. Each punch blurred into the last, my vision narrowing, my balance falling. I tried to defend myself, tried to articulate reason through the chaos, but my words were lost in the torrent of force.

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"Jack! Watch out! Behind you!" Ruth's voice cut through the haze, sharp and urgent.

I fell down as Jack let go of my shirt, only to glimpse the danger beyond. Kurt Borch, twenty feet away, had a pistol drawn, aimed directly at Jack. My heart raced; the world contracted to threat and reflex.

Gunfire cracked. Jack's first shot rang out as Borch's pistol twitched. Another followed while the word was still sharp in the air. A flash of red on his shirt marked the first. Borch forced at the knees, then at the waist, collapsing in a heap on the ground.

"Hold it, all of you! Get your hands up! Now, too. *KuhNaga!*" Gerd's voice commanded, carrying authority even through the pandemonium.

I pushed myself erect, the world tilting and sharp with pain. Blood gushed from my nose, and I pressed the sleeve of my jacket to it, trying to staunch the flow. My head throbbled, vision blurred, but I forced myself to focus on the scene before me.

As I stumbled forward, still reeling from the blow, I collided with Ruth Ortheis. She shoved me away with a force that left me stumbling back a step. Her attention was already on the small, crushed body on the ground. She dropped to her knees beside it, hands trembling, fingers brushing the fur, and I heard the faint jingle of the silver charm ball on Goldblond's neck chain. Her soft crying pierced the chaos.

Juan Jimenez had climbed down from the airboat, eyes wide with horror at the sight of Kurt Borch sprawled on the ground.